

FLIGHT BOOK

A US Marine Corps helicopter pilot's flight-crew checklist notebook shows a hand-drawn map of the approach to an air facility, and heading and distance details for radio navigation.



Since North Vietnamese aircraft did not venture into the South, the only threat to US helicopters came from ground fire. When a helicopter landing zone was closely hemmed in by Viet Cong, this was a very considerable threat. Each Bell UH-1, the war's ubiquitous utility helicopter, had a gunner stationed at the open door, "flying shotgun" like the guard on a Wild West stagecoach. The helicopter crews' war was close up and personal. As journalist Frank Harvey wrote: "They didn't

hurl impersonal thunderbolts from the heights in supersonic jets. They came muttering down to the paddies and hootch lines, fired at close range... They took hits through their plastic windshields and through their rotor blades." The

helicopter's role extended still further to that of aerial activity, especially with the arrival of AH-1 Cobras in 1967. A salvo of rockets from the helicopter gunship was estimated to be the equivalent of a barrage from 105-mm howitzers. The

helicopter gunship joined a broad array of aircraft that the army could call on for close air support. The dependence of ground troops on air power in Vietnam has often been criticized as excessive. Infantry patrols that encountered guerrillas might make little effort to take them on, hastily calling in air support to do the job for them. There are stories of jittery lieutenants summoning an air strike to deal with a sniper. But the desire to avoid pitched infantry battles was understandable, and the aircraft were there to be

**SEARCH AND DESTROY**

A wave of combat helicopters of the 1st Air Cavalry Division flies over a remote landing zone in the jungle during a "search and destroy" mission in South Vietnam. An entire battalion could be flown to the point of battle. One Vietnam War pilot commented that formations of helicopters "always looked sloppy... because no two ships were ever at the same altitude."